



WHAT'S IN THE WORKS

- **Plastic park:** Spread over 50 acres, around 100 plastic processing units will be set up here
- **New Gorakhpur town:** A 6,000-acre satellite town being planned on the outskirts of Gorakhpur
- **Varun Beverages, Keyaan Distilleries & India Glycols Ltd** are among the key private investors
- **Gorakhpur Metrolite,** the two-corridor metro rail project, is estimated to come up at a cost of Rs 4,600 crore

₹1.71 LAKH CRORE
The investment Gorakhpur attracted at the Uttar Pradesh Investors Summit held in February this year

₹12,000 CRORE
The development funding Gorakhpur bagged in just the first year of Yogi Adityanath's second term as CM

One of the most remarkable transformations is that of the Ramgarh Tal, earlier known as '*khooni nalla*' thanks to its grisly reputation as being a hotspot of criminal activities. Today, the lakeside has been turned into a beautiful promenade, where the city's residents can take a stroll, go for boat rides, or eat snacks at the kiosks. CCTV cameras ensure safety; the area also has a four-lane road for motorists, benches for senior citizens, not to mention pretty fountains and tree cover.

Connectivity is another area of prime focus. With more four- and six-lane highways coming up and the 91.3-km Gorakhpur Link Expressway that will connect the city to the Purvanchal Expressway, travel to neighbouring districts will get easier. Last month, Prime Minister Narendra Modi flagged off the Gorakhpur-Lucknow Vande Bharat train. By 2024, the city is slated to have a two-corridor metro rail network with 27 stations, connecting key areas such as the BRD Medical College, the Gorakhpur railway station, the Gorakhnath Math, the Gorakhpur University and the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS). The AIIMS, in fact, was set up in 2016, but became operational only in 2019 after its outpatient department was launched that year and the institute started its first MBBS batch with 50 students. Spread across nearly 100 acres, the institute has turned Gorakhpur into the health capital of eastern UP, catering to people from areas such as Maharajganj, Deoria, Basti Kushinagar, and Azamgarh.

Gorakhpur is also looking forward to the 100-acre regional film city that actor and Gorakhpur MP Ravi Kishan announced last year. "The aim is to ensure that local youth can pursue their dreams here instead of leaving for Bombay," he had said. "UP has immense talent, they need a platform. If they get employment here, why would they struggle in Bombay?" Several Bhojpuri production houses have begun work too. On the culture and tourism front, while the famous Gorakhnath temple has been renovated, several big hotel chains such as the Taj Vivanta, Ramada, Holiday Inn and Marriott are already in the process of setting up shop in the city.

The changed fortunes of their city have the locals excited. Himanshu Kamlapuri, an entrepreneur here, is all praise for the government's efforts. However, he wants it to focus on small businesses as well. "Apart from big industries, the government should focus on the welfare of local businessmen, upcoming industries should be encouraged to tie up with them," he says. His brother Simant, an engineering student, is equally optimistic. "Gorakhpur has changed in the past five years," he says. "You can see new highways, quality roads and an almost 24-hour power supply. I never thought I'd settle here, but now, if I get a job in the upcoming industries, I'd definitely want to." For a state long scorned as being an economic laggard that exports the largest number of job-seeking migrants, that's no small vote of confidence. ■